

L-46: PYQ MAPPING

Future of Caste | Impact of Religions on Indian Society | Anthropology P1 & GS1

TREND ANALYSIS

Frequency & Pattern

Topic	Frequency	UPSC Angle
Future of Caste	High (every 2-3 yrs)	Persistence vs transformation; data-based analysis
Buddhism Impact	Moderate (10/15 mark Qs)	Social reform; art/education legacy
Jainism Impact	Low-Moderate (often clubbed)	Compared with Buddhism; ahimsa legacy
Islam Impact	Moderate	Art/architecture/syncretism; composite culture
Christianity Impact	Low-Moderate	Modernisation; NE India; conversion debate
Composite Culture (All religions)	High	15-mark integrative questions

A. FUTURE OF CASTE SYSTEM

2023 | Anthropology P2 | 10 marks

"Is caste losing its significance in urban India? Discuss with evidence."

- **Srinivas** — Sanskritisation/Westernisation as adaptive mechanisms
- Data: 5% inter-caste marriages (IHDS-2); DICCI as counter-example
- **Banerjee** study on IT hiring; but 27% untouchability persists (NCAER)
- **Beteille** — caste vs class tension; EWS quota 2019 as shift

2022 | GS1 | 15 marks

"Discuss the changing nature of caste system in India. Is caste becoming less hierarchical and more associational?"

- **Kolenda** — 1000-year system won't vanish; **Jaffrelot** — empowerment via caste politics
- Caste associations (Yadav, Brahmin assoc.) = political pressure groups
- Mandal 1992 affirmed caste; Bihar Survey 2023 = data-driven approach
- Conclude with Beteille: identity-based, not ritual-based persistence

2019 | GS1 | 10 marks

"Is the practice of untouchability still prevalent in India? Discuss with data."

- NCAER data: 27% practise untouchability; breakdown by caste & religion
- UP/Rajasthan hereditary occupation data (sweepers, leather workers)
- **Prohibition of Manual Scavengers Act 2013**; NAMASTE 2022
- Counter: slow decline among urban youth; technological modernisation

2017 | GS1 | 10 marks

"What are the obstacles to inter-caste marriages in India?"

- **Narmadeshwar Prasad** survey (1957): 35.3% saw inter-caste marriage as remedy
- Only 5% achieved (IHDS-2); endogamy as social norm
- NFHS-5: inter-caste linked to better child nutrition (positive framing)
- Pew 2021: younger Indians more open; matrimonial platforms changing trends

2016 | Anthropology P1 | 15 marks

"Critically examine the future of the caste system in India."

- Frame: persistence in NEW forms (not disappearance)
- **Srinivas** (adaptation), **Ambedkar** (abolition needed), **Beteille** (caste-class)
- Chandra Bhan Prasad — Dalit Capitalism as alternative empowerment
- EWS 2019 + Bihar Survey 2023 as recent developments

B. IMPACT OF BUDDHISM

2021 | Anthropology P1 | 15 marks

"Discuss the impact of Buddhism on Indian society and culture."

- **R.S. Sharma** (achieved status); **Uma Chakravarti** (women/Therigatha)
- **Radhakrishnan** (civic ethics); **Gombrich** (reasoned inquiry in Pali)
- Education: Nalanda/Taxila (**Majumdar**); Art: Gandhara/Mathura (**Basham**)
- Economic: trade-route monasteries (**Upinder Singh, Kulke**)
- Negative: military decline; monastic withdrawal (Thapar)

2018 | GS1 | 10 marks

"How did Buddhism contribute to social equality in ancient India?"

- Rejected varna; Sangha open to all castes/genders
- **R.S. Sharma**: achieved > ascribed status
- Women as nuns (Therigatha — **Uma Chakravarti**)
- Ashoka's dhamma = ethical kingship (**Thapar**); modern: Ambedkar's Neo Buddhism

2015 | Anthropology P1 | 10 marks

"Examine the role of Buddhism in promoting education and intellectual freedom."

- Pali language → democratised knowledge (**Gombrich**: reasoned inquiry)
- Universities: Nalanda, Vikramshila, Taxila, Valabhi
- **Majumdar**: at Taxila, law/medicine/grammar coexisted with Buddhist studies
- Literature: Tipitaka, Jataka, Therigatha, Apabhramsa writings

C. IMPACT OF JAINISM

2020 | Anthropology P1 | 10 marks

"Compare the social reform contributions of Buddhism and Jainism in ancient India."

- Both rejected Vedic orthodoxy & caste; both used vernacular (Pali/Prakrit)
- Buddhism: more missionary + widespread; Jainism: non-missionary, Vaishya base
- **Thapar**: both challenged Brahmanical orthodoxy
- **Basham**: Jain moral vocabulary (restraint) vs Buddhist civic ethics (Radhakrishnan)
- Jainism's limitation: social isolation (strict ahimsa → separation)

2017 | GS1 | 10 marks

"Discuss the contribution of Jainism to Indian art and architecture."

- Ellora complex: Buddhism + Hinduism + Jainism = spirit of tolerance
- Gommateshwara Bahubali at Shravanabelagola
- Kalpa Sutra paintings (Parshvanatha & Mahavira biographies)
- Dharamshalas as civic hubs (**R.C. Majumdar**: mercantile patronage)

D. IMPACT OF ISLAM

2022 | GS1 | 15 marks

"How has Islam influenced Indian art, architecture, music, and social life?"

- Architecture: domes/arches/minarets; Taj Mahal, Buland Darwaza
- Music: Sitar/Tabla; Qawwali; Kathak (**Upadhyaya**: Feeders of Indian Culture)
- Language: Urdu (synthesis); Ghalib; Persian historiography (**Pritchett**)
- Sufism: syncretic culture (**Eaton**); Nizamuddin Auliya case study
- Social: one God = equality (**Harbans Mukhia**); sulhe-kul (**Tara Chand**)

2019 | Anthropology P1 | 10 marks

"Discuss the role of Sufism in creating a syncretic Indian culture."

- **Richard Eaton**: Sufis integrated local practices → syncretic culture
- **Tara Chand**: sulhe-kul = peace for all
- Khanqahs: refuge irrespective of caste/creed (**Rosherduddin Khan**)
- Qawwali (Nizamuddin); Kathak = Hindu + Muslim gharanas; Amir Khusro

2016 | GS1 | 10 marks

"Evaluate the impact of Islam on Indian painting traditions."

- Mughal miniature painting: from Persian miniature (Chinese origin)
- Confined to book illustrations or muraqqa albums
- Peaked under Jahangir's reign
- Broader: Charbagh gardens; calligraphy; geometric patterns in architecture

E. IMPACT OF CHRISTIANITY

2021 | GS1 | 10 marks

"Critically examine the role of Christianity in modernising Indian society."

- **Victor D'Souza**: Christianity = modernisation + economic development
- Education: English medium; Mizoram 92% literacy; **Teotonio de Souza**
- Health: CMC Vellore; **Sweet** (institutionalised hospitals)
- **B.B. Misra**: channel of Western political ideas (liberalism)
- Critical: **Shourie** (assimilationist); **Susan Bayly** (conversion conflicts: Kandhamal 2008)

2018 | Anthropology P1 | 10 marks

"How did Christianity contribute to educational development in tribal India?"

- NE India: missions filled government gaps — schools + hospitals
- Mizoram 92% literacy = direct outcome of missionary education
- **Teotonio de Souza**: shaped early Western-educated elite
- But: **cultural assimilation** sometimes eroded indigenous practices (same scholar)

F. COMPOSITE / INTEGRATIVE QUESTIONS

2023 | GS1 | 15 marks

"How has the impact of various religions shaped the composite culture of India?"

- Buddhism: equality + intellectual freedom + Pali democratisation
- Jainism: ahimsa + austerity + Prakrit + art (Ellora = tolerance symbol)
- Islam: Urdu synthesis + Sufi syncretism + architecture + music
- Christianity: modernisation + English + healthcare + heritage rediscovery
- Conclude: India = absorptive civilisation; each religion contributed to composite identity

2015 | GS1 | 10 marks

"Describe any four cultural elements of diversity in India and rate their significance in building a national identity."

- Language diversity (Pali/Prakrit/Urdu/English — all from religious impacts)
- Architectural heritage (stupas + temples + mosques + churches)
- Music/Dance (Qawwali + Kathak + devotional traditions)
- Ethical frameworks (ahimsa + civic ethics + sulhe-kul + universal brotherhood)